

It's time to **LIBERATE** our history. Let's rescue it from the **PRESSURES** and prejudices of new India.

The past is a foreign country, they do things differently there." L.P. Hartley's famous opening line has a remarkable resonance for those who have read his brilliant classic *The Go-Between*. This proverbial opening, if heeded, could also augur a central shift in our perceptions of the past. Such a shift is necessary so that the study of our enormously rich and omnipresent past stops being stymied by the present, by those who either expect the past to have been like the present or seek solace for their present discontents in past practices.

That the sword these days is frequently summoned to silence the pen is undeniable. Authors, university departments, and institutes that write and research about matters that don't fit hagiographic versions of history, have been physically attacked. It is realistic to expect that such unseemly spectacles will continue to unfold for the simple reason that our past is imprisoned in our present day ideas of what it supposedly was. This proclivity, in fact, reminds me of the dismay displayed by the Afghan, Ahmad Shah Abdali, in the battle of Panipat in 1761. Apparently, Abdali had never been confronted with unclothed troopers. When he realised that as the main ally of Shuja ud-Daulah, he had such Hindu gosains or warrior ascetics indirectly fighting for him, he prudishly lectured Shuja on the "impropriety of unrestrained kafirs, naked in front and behind...parading and lounging in front of Muslims, and ordered them removed to a distance from his camp." The gosains did comply with Abdali's request, moved away from his line of vision, and, notwithstanding the Afghan affront, acquitted themselves well in the battlefield. The problem, though, with history is that, unlike these



Prisoners of the past:
VHP workers trying to stop a train in Indore in protest against the controversial Sethu Samudram project

Hidden History

PRACTICALLY EVERY HARAPPAN CIVILISATION SITE WHERE ANIMAL BONES ARE FOUND HAS YIELDED CATTLE BONES. YET MODERN INDIANS FAIL TO DIGEST ANCIENT INDIA'S FONDNESS FOR BEEF.

warrior ascetics, it cannot acquit itself in an excellent way if we banish those cultural practices that fail to measure up to our ideas of what the past was all about.

On the other hand, how liberating it will be to release history from such expectations. For one, if we accept that people and cultures in ancient and medieval India were different from us, we would feel no sense of retrospective shock about what they ate or drank or wore, or for that matter, what they didn't wear. I am thinking here of ancient India's most powerful emperor whose first portrait shows his queen without clothes. The